

■ MDK 2

MDK was one of those unfortunate games that had everything going for it except sales. It had great graphics, wicked level design, and critical acclaim. Though it went largely unnoticed, its sequel offered some redemption to the characters and made them gaming icons.

MDK 2 is a third person shooter where you control three characters: Dr Fluke Hawkins, Max the six-legged dog, and Kurt the Janitor. Each of these characters lend itself to an innovative form of gameplay: Max can use four weapons at a time, which makes him ridiculously powerful; Kurt has sniping and paragliding skills; and Dr Hawkins is the wacky scientist who creates devastating weapons by combining items at hand together.

■ Diablo II

In 1996, Blizzard, the company that perfected the RTS genre with *Warcraft*, unleashed *Diablo*. Before *Diablo*, RPGs and Action games never found a common ground. In many respects *Diablo* is a simple action game, requiring only the left mouse button to play, but it has the storyline of an adventure game and the open-endedness of an old-school RPG.

In *Diablo* you play either as a warrior, rogue, or sorcerer who has journeyed to the town of Tristram for whatever reason you want (money, adventure, obsessive-compulsive desire to beat the unliving crap out of the undead) to fight back an invading demonic horde from beneath the town, led by the strongest of the Evils, *Diablo* himself.

■ Tetris

Russia's greatest export! No other game has had the impact and fan following to match *Tetris*. A simple game, the objective is to stack falling blocks of four into a line. You do so until infinity, or until you lose. But within that game are multiple layers of strategy and approaches that fascinate both the layman and the mathematician. The game is simple and can be played on even the most primitive computer and yet can be seen on some of the most powerful consoles and PCs. In fact, it sold 30 million copies on the Nintendo Gameboy. Add an equal number to the uncounted clones sold in grey markets as 'Brick Game', in key chains, in handhelds and cell phones. Ironically, Alexey Pajinov, the creator of this game did not make a single rouble out of the royalties, all of which went to the Soviet Ministry of Commerce.

■ Counter-Strike

What started out as a simple mod on the *Half-Life* engine two years ago has now gone through several enhancements, improved network code, balanced gameplay, and voice support. *Counter-Strike* enjoys popularity unlike any other mod; more people play it online than *Unreal Tournament* and *Quake III* combined. The game basically boils down to this: two teams, terrorists and anti-terrorists, fight it out. The team that survives wins the round. Since you have to play as a team, it creates a unique team play atmosphere where cooperation is as crucial as your ping. More than anything else, it creates gameplay that never gets boring. Even after playing a particular map to death, there are always new permutations and possibilities to explore.

Since it's based on a three-year-old *Half-Life* engine, it can play on the leanest machines. A game fit for both LAN parties and professional gaming tournaments. Best played online or on a LAN, this is the perfect game for after office *Strike* takes the cake—it's free.

■ Max Payne

With fantastically slick narration, the Max engine, and Bullet-Time motion, *Max Payne* is one of the shortest and sweetest gaming experiences you'll ever have. No game to date has featured such sharp visual quality in its environments—environments that not only look real, but also act real. John Woo was the main source of inspiration for some of the intentional movie-like elements.

Max Payne has Bullet-Time, an effect much like the slow-motion scenes in *The Matrix*. This effect causes the entire game to slow down significantly in a dramatic effect that is designed to give Max a lethal advantage over his enemies. *Max Payne* is about style, about fast pacing, and that little compromise on realism keeps this game centered on the sweet spot all the way.

■ Need for Speed 4: High Stakes

Recreated through close collaborations with the world's most renowned car manufacturers, *Need for Speed: High Stakes* lets you unleash a dream collection of cars on the wide, open roads. The star of the show is, of course, the police mode, which is almost a whole new game in itself. Ramming a few hundred thousand dollars worth of vehicles off the road is pretty good fun, and makes *High Stakes* worth it.

The *Need for Speed* series may not win accolades from the purists, but when it comes to the thrill of riding some of the world's fastest sports cars, nothing comes close. This game might have sequels that are better looking and counterparts that are simulated to the very minute detail, but in terms of replayability and clean fun, this is simply the pinnacle of sports car racing.